

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract about the Urban Dictionary:

Urban Dictionary

The Urban Dictionary was started in 1999 by Aaron Peckham. Since then, it has become an archive for any new term or slang word, particularly those used to describe the behaviour and activities that have arisen because of social media and the web. More than 7 million entries are listed on the site and 2,000 definitions are added daily and it has become the default dictionary for many users.

The Urban Dictionary documents words, photos and videos posted on Facebook, Instagram, Twitter etc. with words/phrases that would not be found in a standard dictionary. Anyone can add a word, no matter how offensive or controversial. Submissions are approved and rated by volunteers and visitors to the website. Mr Peckham said that he rarely edits or removes words unless they reveal someone's private information. Because Urban Dictionary's users contribute and vote on which definitions are most popular, it says something about our current culture – something that traditional dictionaries can't do.

'People have always been inventive with language,' said Katherine Connor Martin, the head of U.S. Dictionaries at Oxford University Press. 'In the 19th century, if young people were using slang terms among themselves, those words had to become very well entrenched before anything came into popular use,' she added. 'Now, if someone invents a new word on Twitter, it can go viral.'

Your group has to do a project to compile a dictionary of English words commonly used by teenagers. Discuss with your group how to carry out this project. You may want to talk about:

- useful sources for collecting words commonly used by teenagers
- ways to decide what words to include in your dictionary
- how to present the information for the dictionary in an interesting way
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like to learn new English words?
2. How often do you use a dictionary?
3. Are dictionaries useful in learning a language?
4. Do you like to learn new words from pop songs and rap music?
5. Should schools promote the use of the Urban Dictionary?
6. Do you think the Urban Dictionary is a reliable source of information?
7. Do you think slang plays an important role in learning a language?
8. Should standard dictionaries include words from the Urban Dictionary?